feature[23] Design | Commercial Model

So What?

- Make clearer investment decisions
- Find new opportunities
- Improve how people work
- Create products and experiences that better serve the business
- Leave with a clear direction, a design, a working concept, a stronger team, or a concrete roadmap plan they can act on
- Move forward with or without feature[23] building the product

Our Design Approach

- **Start with the business:**
  - Understand the business goals, their measures for success, their constraints, what is working, and what is getting in the way.
- **Discover opportunities:**
  - Identify new ways to grow, improve the business, and get more from existing products, systems, and capabilities.
- **Understand the people:**
  - See how customers and employees actually work, where they struggle, the concepts in their work, the activities that drive that work, and what they need to accomplish.
- **Activities before screens**
  - Understand workflows, decisions, and friction before designing screens.
- **Concepts before features:**
  - Define core concepts, relationships, rules, and behaviors behind the experience
- **Understand the work:**
  - Map the steps, decisions, and handoffs a product needs to support before jumping into screens.
- **Systems over screens:**
  - Design coherent products and workflows, not isolated interfaces, that support both people and business goals.
- **Make ideas real and test them:**
  - Use research and working concepts in Studio to evaluate direction before major investment.
- Conceptual integrity:**

- Keep the product consistent with the agreed direction, including accessibility and implementation quality.

1. Business Goals & Desired Outcomes

Business Goal	Desired Outcomes
Grow revenue	**Grow the business:** Increase sales, enter new markets, retain customers, and create new revenue opportunities Find new opportunities: identify unmet needs, new products, AI opportunities, and additional value within the existing business
Improve profitability	Improve operations: reduce manual work, eliminate duplication, improve productivity, and control costs
Make sound investments	Make better investment decisions: decide where to spend money, what to prioritize, and what is worth building, improving, or killing
Strengthen competitive advantage	Build vs. buy: Decide what to own: Decide which capabilities the business needs to control, what existing software can handle, and where building, integrating, or modernizing creates more value than adapting the business to a vendor. i keep thinking 'own your competitive advantage'
Get better returns from technology	Get more from existing investments: how do we get our clients to get more out of their existing investments? improve adoption, consolidate tools, and make existing technology, data, and capabilities more useful?
Reduce investment risk	**Prove something will work:** Test ideas, concepts, and assumptions before committing significant money or resources.
Improve organizational execution	**Resolve competing priorities:** Help leadership, product, operations, and engineering agree on what matters and where to focus.
Increase productivity	Understand what's holding us back: determine whether problems come from products, processes, people, technology, or a combination. it will happen
Grow through new offerings	Create something new: bring new products, services, experiences, and business capabilities to market/business
Improve customer retention and employee effectiveness	Improve customer and employee experiences: make products easier to use, more accessible, and more effective at supporting real work (concepts/activities)
Build stronger teams and delivery	Strengthen internal capabilities: improve team expertise, design quality, standards, processes, and the ability to deliver (whether

Business Goal	Desired Outcomes
capability	thats for the business, design teams, external teams, internal, etc)
Stay competitive as needs change	Keep moving forward: adapt products and experiences as customers, operations, and business needs change. is the current direction the same path we should be taking?

2. What They're Saying

Working buyer language.

Problem / Unknown	What We Might Hear
Growth	"Where else can we grow?" "Are we missing opportunities with what we already have?"
Operations	"Why are we doing so much of this manually?" "Are our processes slowing us down?"
Investment	"We have several ideas. Which one is actually worth investing in?"
Build vs. Buy	"Why are we changing our processes to fit this software?" "Should we keep paying for this platform, improve it, or build something we own?" "What would owning it let us do that we can't do today?" "Has AI changed what we can afford to build?"
Existing Technology	"We've spent a lot on this software. Are we getting what we paid for?"
Validation	"How do we know this will work before we spend the money?"
Alignment	"Everyone has a different opinion about what we should do next."
Opportunity	"What else could we be doing with our technology, data, or people?"
Business Friction	"Why is our product holding us back?" "Is the problem our technology or how we work?"
New Products	"We know what we want to accomplish, but we're not sure what the product should look like or how it should work."
User Experience	"Are our people actually efficient with the technology we're giving them?" "Why are customers struggling with our product?"
Team Capabilities	"Our engineers can build it, but we don't have anyone designing the experience."
AI	"Where would AI actually help our business?" "How do we use AI without making our existing problems worse?"
Ongoing Improvement	"We're constantly adding features, but is the product actually getting better?"

Problem / Unknown	What We Might Hear
Unclear Direction	"We know something needs to change. We just don't know where to start."

3. What the Research Supports

Research	Relevant Findings
Grant Thornton: Shift Your Tech Strategy (2025)	93% of surveyed executives are increasing technology investment, but only 27% report full alignment with business goals. Technology investment doesn't guarantee business value.
Grant Thornton: Make Technology an Engine for Profitability (2025)	Better utilization, user adoption, and operational efficiency are necessary to realize more value from technology.
National Center for the Middle Market: The Case for Digital Transformation	Middle-market organizations pursue digital investment to grow, improve operations, and compete. Clear digital direction is associated with stronger business performance.
National Center for the Middle Market: Digitizing the Customer Experience	Customer experience matters to middle-market competitiveness. Organizations struggle to realize the full benefit of their digital investments.
Productboard: What 100 Product Leaders Told Us (2025)	43% of surveyed product leaders report increased accountability for business outcomes and revenue. Teams face pressure to improve strategy, alignment, and delivery.
Productboard: AI in Product Management (2025)	Product leaders face pressure to introduce AI, while many organizations struggle to connect experimentation to measurable outcomes.
Thoughtworks: Build Versus Buy, a Strategic Framework	Build vs. buy involves a tradeoff between speed and proven capabilities on one side, and control and customization on the other. The decision affects how the organization works.
Retool: 2026 Build vs. Buy Report	In a survey of 817 Retool customers and builders, 35% reported replacing at least one SaaS tool with a custom build; 78% expected to build more internal tools in 2026. Signals growing interest in ownership and AI-assisted development, not proof that building is always cheaper.

4. How We Apply This

Business goal → Desired outcome → Problem / unknown → Design engagement → What they get

5. Validation Needed

- Compare buyer language against actual client and sales conversations.
- Identify which problems most frequently lead to paid engagements.
- Separate executive, product owner, operations, and engineering buying triggers.
- Connect validated needs to our engagement catalog.
- Identify gaps we cannot currently serve.
- Validate whether clients will purchase Build vs. Buy decision work independently, and which software ownership questions trigger those engagements.

6. Which Business Goals and Problems Should We Sell Against First?

Assess which goals and problems to sell against first:

- **Client evidence:**
  - Are existing clients asking for this? Have we delivered similar work?
- **Willingness to pay:**
  - Will clients purchase a design engagement to address it?
- **Commercial potential:**
  - Can it produce profitable, repeatable, or ongoing work?
- **Delivery fit:**
  - Can we define the scope, outcomes, and deliverables with our existing capabilities?
- **Studio advantage:**
  - Can Studio help us deliver or validate the work better?

Next: Prioritize opportunities by evidence and commercial fit. Test Build vs. Buy as a standalone decision engagement.

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7. What They Buy

Design Engagements

Engagement	Client Outcome
Opportunity & Discovery	Identify and evaluate opportunities, including new value in existing capabilities.
Product Direction	Define, compare, and validate a product direction.

Engagement	Client Outcome
Build vs. Buy / Modernization Decision	Understand what to own, build, buy, integrate, or improve before committing to a technology path.
Product Design	Create usable, accessible, and build-ready products, workflows, and experiences.
Design Review & Audit	Understand what needs improvement and why.
Product Improvement	Improve and modernize existing products and experiences.
Design Systems & Enablement	Strengthen internal design capabilities, practices, and consistency.
AI Opportunity & Experience	Identify valuable AI opportunities and design and validate human-AI experiences.
Design Partnership	Provide ongoing design expertise, execution, and improvement.

Engagement names are working labels. Not every offering needs to be a separate sales motion.

Here's What You Get When You Buy From Us

Of course, actual outputs depend on the engagement scope. Each engagement should leave the client with something they can use to make a decision, move work forward, or improve how their team operates.

Engagement	What the Client Receives
Opportunity & Discovery	Research findings, opportunity areas, prioritized options, and recommendations on what to pursue.
Product Direction	Defined goals and workflows, explored concepts, validated direction, and a path for what happens next.
Build vs. Buy / Modernization Decision	Needs and workflow assessment, fit/gap findings, decision criteria, future-state concepts where useful, and a recommended investment path with tradeoffs.
Product Design	User flows, interaction designs, interfaces, working prototypes, and design assets ready to guide implementation.
Design Review & Audit	Evidence of what's working and what isn't, prioritized findings, and recommendations or a remediation plan.
Product Improvement	Improved workflows and interfaces, tested changes where applicable, and clear priorities for continued improvement.

Engagement	What the Client Receives
Design Systems & Enablement	Reusable components and patterns, standards, governance, and documentation or coaching the client's team can use.
AI Opportunity & Experience	Evaluated AI use cases, human-AI workflow designs, testable concepts, and recommendations on where AI should or shouldn't be used.
Design Partnership	Ongoing design capacity, completed design work, maintained assets, and regular direction and quality reviews.

Build vs. Buy: What Design Contributes

Their problem:
The software we have is shaping how we work, and we aren't sure whether to keep adapting to it or own something better suited to our business.

What we evaluate:

- **The work:**
  - Actual activities, workflows, workarounds, user needs, and where the current approach fails.
- **Fit:**
  - What existing products support, what needs to change, and which gaps matter to the business.
- **Control:**
  - Which workflows, data, integrations, experiences, and roadmap decisions create competitive advantage or need to stay in the business's hands.
- **Alternatives:**
  - Keep, improve, integrate, modernize, buy, build, or combine approaches.
- **Economics:**
  - The cost of adapting the business to software versus adapting software to the business, including licensing, implementation, maintenance, and future change.
- **AI:**
  - Whether AI-assisted development changes what's practical to build, without confusing a working prototype with a production-ready system.

What the client receives:
A current-state needs assessment, fit/gap findings, future-state concepts where useful, decision criteria, and a recommended path with its tradeoffs. Studio can help make a proposed workflow testable before a larger investment.

Our role:
Design leads the understanding, modeling, and validation of business and user needs. Engineering and financial input inform technical feasibility, lifecycle costs, and implementation decisions.

Existing Service Architecture

The Design Market Strategy defines six pillars. These are capability areas, not nine more engagements:

- **Clarity & Concept Strategy:**
  - Opportunity framing, direction, workshops, and conceptual design.
- **Heuristic Evaluations & Design Audits:**
  - Current-state assessments, usability, consistency, and experience quality.
- **Accessibility, Compliance & Experience Risk:**
  - Accessibility audits, remediation planning, and design governance.
- **Product Modernization Enablement:**
  - Legacy experiences, fragmented workflows, and future-state direction.
- **Studio:**
  - A shared product-building environment for concepts, prototypes, design systems, and collaboration.
- **AI Design Systems:**
  - Structured, reusable, automation-aware design foundations.

Existing Service Packaging Concepts

The Market Strategy also identifies these potential purchasable services:

- Clarity & Concept Engagement
- Design Audit & Current-State Assessment
- Accessibility & Experience Risk Review
- Product Modernization Enablement
- Studio Launch
- AI Design System Accelerator
- Understanding Workshops

These are proposals to package and validate, not a claim that every service is currently sold as a standalone offer.

8. Commercial Models

- **Fixed-Fee:**
  - Defined outcomes, scope, deliverables, and price.
- **Project-Based:**
  - Custom engagements with agreed scope and milestones.
- **Ongoing Partnership:**
  - Dedicated design capacity or continued work.
- **Capability & Enablement:**
  - Coaching, systems, tooling, and practice improvement, sold as fixed-fee or ongoing work.

9. How We Contribute

Our contribution modes define our role and responsibilities within an engagement. They are **not** services and are **not** required sequential phases.

Mode	Our Role
Innovating with design	Lead exploration where the opportunity and direction are undefined.
Leading with design	Own design direction, concepts, and design decisions.
Executing with design	Produce and implement defined design work.
Supporting with design	Collaborate with teams to extend, maintain, and improve products.
Reviewing with design	Evaluate, validate, and recommend improvements.

An engagement can use multiple modes.

Example Engagement Mapping

Engagement	Typical Contribution Modes
Opportunity & Discovery	Innovating, Leading, Reviewing
Product Direction	Leading, Innovating, Reviewing
Build vs. Buy / Modernization Decision	Leading, Reviewing, Innovating
Product Design	Leading, Executing
Design Review & Audit	Reviewing
Product Improvement	Reviewing, Supporting, Executing
Design Systems & Enablement	Leading, Executing, Supporting, Reviewing

Engagement	Typical Contribution Modes
AI Opportunity & Experience	Innovating, Leading, Reviewing, Executing
Design Partnership	Varies by client needs

10. Our Capabilities

Strategy & Discovery

- Business and product strategy
- Opportunity identification and modeling
- Current-state and future-state analysis
- Product discovery and definition
- Build vs. buy analysis
- Modernization strategy
- Concept architecture
- Activity and workflow modeling

Workshops & Facilitation

- Understanding workshops
- Clarity workshops
- Gap analysis workshops
- Opportunity exploration
- Stakeholder alignment
- Concept and ideation workshops
- User activity and workflow workshops
- Product direction workshops

Research & Validation

- User interviews and research
- User and stakeholder discovery
- Usability testing
- Concept validation
- Prototype testing
- User behavior and workflow analysis
- Heuristic evaluations

Product & Experience Design

- Conceptual design
- UX and UI design
- Interaction design
- Information architecture
- User flows and journey mapping
- Wireframing and prototyping
- Visual design and interface refinement
- UX writing and content design
- Responsive and mobile design
- Design in code

Design Systems & Enablement

- Design system creation and architecture
- Component libraries and reusable patterns
- Design tokens and governance
- Design operations and workflows
- Team coaching and enablement
- Design-to-engineering collaboration
- AI-ready design systems

Audits & Improvement

- UX and product audits
- Accessibility audits and remediation planning
- WCAG 2.2 AA evaluations
- Design system audits
- Design debt and consistency reviews
- Design-to-code drift reviews
- Product modernization and redesign

AI & Intelligent Experiences

- AI opportunity exploration
- AI experience and interaction design
- Human-AI workflow design
- AI-assisted concept generation
- AI-assisted prototyping
- Agent-aware design systems and workflows

- AI experience evaluation and validation

Additional Specialized Capabilities in the Design Playbook

- Speculative and innovation modeling
- Compliance and regulated-system design
- UX writing and behavioral communication
- Systems design and workflow architecture
- Implementation collaboration, including HTML and SCSS

11. Studio

Studio is our shared product-building environment.

- Working concepts and prototypes
- Reusable components and patterns
- Living design systems
- Client collaboration and validation
- Design-to-code continuity
- Product knowledge and decisions
- AI-assisted design and development
- MCP server for connecting compatible AI tools and agents

Studio supports our engagements and how we deliver them. It doesn't require a client to purchase an engineering engagement.

12. How Clients Engage Us

- **Exploration-Based:**
  - They know something needs to change or see potential for something new, but don't know where to start, what to do, or which direction to take.
- **Outcome-Based:**
  - They know what they want to accomplish but need help figuring out how to get there.
- **Expertise-Based:**
  - They know the type of team or expertise they need.
- **Service-Based:**
  - They know the specific work or service they want to purchase.

All four paths connect to the same engagement catalog and capabilities.

13. Marketing & Content Strategy

Status: Three messaging angles selected. Next step is to write, publish, and measure results.

Channels & Assets

- LinkedIn posts and thought leadership
- Marketing angles tied to real business problems
- Website articles and design-specific content
- Case studies and examples of our work
- Content connecting business needs to our engagements

First Content Series: Build vs. Buy

- What should businesses build, buy, or modernize?
- What should organizations own and control?
- Are existing software platforms holding businesses back?
- How does AI change the economics of building software?
- How can design help make these decisions?

Build vs. Buy is our first content series. Additional topics come from the business goals, desired outcomes, and problems already identified in the commercial model.

Three Agreed Content Topics

Test three messaging angles tied to different business problems before investing in larger campaigns.

Topic	Business Question	What We're Testing
1. Build vs. Buy	"Should we build our own software or keep paying for someone else's?"	Investment decisions, ownership, and competitive advantage
2. What's Holding Us Back?	"Is our technology the problem, or is it how we're using it?" ""	Operational efficiency, product improvement, and modernization
3. Doing More With What We Have	"Are we missing opportunities with the systems, data, and people we already have?"	Growth, opportunity discovery, and AI

Messaging Direction

1. Build vs. Buy

- The economics of building software have changed.
- Owning software can create a competitive advantage.
- Buying a platform means accepting someone else's roadmap.
- AI is changing what's practical to build and maintain.

2. What's Holding Us Back?

- A functioning product isn't necessarily an effective product
- Poor workflows create costs that aren't always visible
- Are employees working efficiently with the technology provided
- Sometimes improving the process matters more than replacing the software

3. Doing More With What We Have

- New opportunities don't always require new product, but they might
- Existing systems and data may contain untapped value
- AI can make existing capabilities more useful
- Understanding how people work can reveal new business opportunities

How We Test

- Start with **one LinkedIn post per topic**.
- Use a recognizable business question, our point of view, and a practical example in each.
- Expand topics that generate meaningful responses into additional posts or website articles.
- Measure meaningful comments, conversations, inquiries, and the business problems people recognize. Likes alone don't establish buying intent.

Why These Three

- **Decision:**
  - What should we invest in?
- **Improvement:**
  - Why aren't we getting the results we expect?
- **Opportunity:**
  - What could we be doing that we aren't?

Lead with the business problem. Introduce Studio and our design capabilities and knowledge context mapping as part of how we help solve it, not as the opening message.